

MOUNT KENYA UNIVERSITY
SCHOOL OF BUSINESS AND ECONOMICS

**INFLUENCE OF PUBLIC PARTICIPATION ON POLICY
IMPLEMENTATION IN MACHAKOS COUNTY GOVERNMENT,
KENYA**

[FULL NAME OF STUDENT]
[REGISTRATION NUMBER]

A Research Proposal Submitted to the School of Business and Economics in Partial
Fulfilment of the Requirements for the Award of the Degree of Master of Public
Administration of Mount Kenya University

SEPTEMBER 2026

DECLARATION

This research proposal is my original work and has not been presented for the award of a degree or for any other award in any other university.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Full Name of Student]

[Registration Number]

Supervisors' Approval

This research proposal has been submitted for examination with our approval as the university supervisors.

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 1]

School of Business and Economics, Mount Kenya University

Signature: _____ Date: _____

[Name of Supervisor 2]

School of Business and Economics, Mount Kenya University

DEDICATION

I dedicate this work to my family for their patience, encouragement and unwavering support throughout my postgraduate studies, and to the residents of Machakos County, whose voices this study seeks to amplify.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

I thank the Almighty God for the gift of life, good health and the strength to undertake this work. I am sincerely grateful to my supervisors for their guidance, constructive criticism and patience throughout the development of this proposal. I also appreciate the lecturers and staff of the School of Business and Economics at Mount Kenya University for the knowledge and support they have offered during my studies. My gratitude extends to my classmates for their encouragement and useful discussions, and to my family for standing with me at every stage. May God bless you all.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

DECLARATION.....	ii
DEDICATION.....	iii
ACKNOWLEDGEMENT.....	iv
TABLE OF CONTENTS.....	v
LIST OF TABLES.....	vii
LIST OF FIGURES.....	viii
ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS.....	ix
OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS.....	x
ABSTRACT.....	xi
CHAPTER ONE INTRODUCTION.....	1
1.1 Background to the Study.....	1
1.2 Statement of the Problem.....	3
1.3 Purpose of the Study.....	4
1.4 Research Objectives.....	4
1.4.1 General Objective.....	4
1.4.2 Specific Objectives.....	4
1.5 Research Questions.....	4
1.6 Research Hypothesis.....	5
1.7 Justification of the Study.....	5
1.8 Significance of the Study.....	5
1.9 Limitations of the Study.....	6
1.10 Delimitations of the Study.....	6
1.11 Assumptions of the Study.....	6
CHAPTER TWO LITERATURE REVIEW.....	7
2.1 Introduction.....	7
2.2 Theoretical Review.....	7
2.2.1 Ladder of Citizen Participation.....	7
2.2.2 Theory of Co-production.....	8
2.3 Empirical Review.....	8
2.3.1 Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation.....	8
2.3.2 Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation.....	9
2.3.3 Challenges Hindering Effective Public Participation.....	10
2.3.4 Public Participation and Effectiveness of Policy Implementation.....	10
2.4 Conceptual Framework.....	11
2.5 Critique of Existing Literature.....	12
2.6 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps.....	12
CHAPTER THREE RESEARCH METHODOLOGY.....	14
3.1 Introduction.....	14
3.2 Research Design.....	14
3.3 Location of the Study.....	14
3.4 Target Population.....	15
3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size.....	15
3.5.1 Sampling Techniques.....	15
3.5.2 Sample Size.....	15
3.6 Research Instruments.....	16
3.7 Pilot Testing.....	17
3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments.....	17
3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments.....	17

3.8 Data Collection Procedures.....	18
3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation.....	18
3.10 Ethical Considerations.....	19
REFERENCES.....	20
APPENDICES.....	24
Appendix I: Letter of Introduction.....	24
Appendix II: Informed Consent Form.....	25
Appendix III: Questionnaire for Residents.....	26
Section A: Demographic Information.....	26
Section B: Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation.....	26
Section C: Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation.....	26
Section D: Challenges Hindering Public Participation.....	27
Section E: Effectiveness of Policy Implementation.....	27
Section F: General Comments.....	28
Appendix IV: Interview Guide for Key Informants.....	29
Appendix V: Work Plan.....	30
Appendix VI: Research Budget.....	30

LIST OF TABLES

- Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps
- Table 3.1: Target Population of Residents
- Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution of Residents
- Table 3.3: Sample of Key Informants
- Table 3.4: Operationalisation of Study Variables

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework

ABBREVIATIONS AND ACRONYMS

CGM	County Government of Machakos
CIDP	County Integrated Development Plan
CoG	Council of Governors
CVI	Content Validity Index
KNBS	Kenya National Bureau of Statistics
MCA	Member of County Assembly
MKU	Mount Kenya University
NACOSTI	National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation
PFM	Public Finance Management
PMC	Project Management Committee
SMS	Short Message Service
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences

OPERATIONAL DEFINITION OF TERMS

Public participation: The process through which residents of Machakos County, individually or through organised groups, take part in decisions and activities that shape how county policies are carried out. In this study it is measured through the level of involvement, the mechanisms used and the barriers experienced.

Policy implementation: The stage of the policy cycle at which approved county policies, programmes and projects are translated into services and physical outputs for residents.

Effectiveness of policy implementation: The degree to which a county policy is delivered on time, meets its stated targets, satisfies its intended beneficiaries and is owned and sustained by the community.

Participation mechanisms: The formal and informal channels through which the county invites and receives citizen input, including public barazas, ward development forums, sector working groups, project management committees and digital or SMS feedback platforms.

Barriers to participation: Structural, informational, economic and institutional factors that prevent residents from taking part meaningfully in implementation processes.

Co-production: An arrangement in which citizens act as active partners with public officials in designing, delivering and assessing public services, rather than as passive recipients.

Tokenism: A form of participation in which citizens are consulted or informed but have no real power to influence the final decision or its execution.

ABSTRACT

Kenya's 2010 Constitution placed citizens at the centre of devolved governance, yet many county policies continue to stall, overrun their timelines or fall short of their targets once they leave the planning table. Much of the existing Kenyan scholarship has examined public participation at the planning and budgeting stages, leaving the implementation stage comparatively under-examined. This study therefore seeks to examine the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government. Specifically, it aims to establish the extent to which residents participate in the implementation of county policies, assess the mechanisms the county uses to facilitate that participation, determine the challenges that constrain it, and examine the relationship between the level of participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation. The study is anchored on Arnstein's Ladder of Citizen Participation and the Theory of Co-production. A descriptive cross-sectional survey design, complemented by key informant interviews, will be adopted. The target population comprises 514,059 residents of Machakos Town, Matungulu and Mwala sub-counties, chosen to represent urban, peri-urban and rural settings, together with county officials responsible for participation and service delivery. Using Yamane's formula and proportionate stratified random sampling, 400 residents will be selected, while 29 key informants will be purposively sampled. Data will be collected through a structured questionnaire and a semi-structured interview guide, both of which will be pre-tested in Kathiani Sub-County. Quantitative data will be analysed using descriptive statistics, Pearson correlation and regression analysis in SPSS, whereas qualitative data will be analysed thematically. The findings are expected to guide the Machakos County Government, the Council of Governors and policy makers in strengthening participatory implementation, and to contribute to the growing literature on devolved governance in Kenya.

Key words: *public participation, policy implementation, devolution, co-production, county government, Machakos*

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

Across the world, governments have come to accept that policies designed without the people they are meant to serve seldom achieve their goals. Citizen participation is now widely treated as a condition for legitimate, responsive and effective public administration, and not merely as a democratic courtesy (Abas et al., 2023). The reasoning is straightforward. When residents are involved, public agencies gain local knowledge, policies are better matched to real needs, and communities are more willing to own and protect what is delivered (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). The difficulty, however, lies less in agreeing with this principle than in making it work in the daily routines of government.

Evidence from Europe illustrates this difficulty. In Finland, Jäntti et al. (2023) observed that embedding participation in local government requires changes at the strategic, executive and citizen-interface levels of an organisation, and that forums alone do little if they are disconnected from the offices that make and execute decisions. A companion study of the city of Helsinki showed that influential participation depends on supportive organisational structures, a receptive culture and adequate resources (Kurkela et al., 2024). In the Netherlands, De Weger et al. (2022) found that residents wanted their involvement in municipal health policy to produce visible changes in their neighbourhoods, and that they needed better communication and more accessible processes to stay engaged. Norwegian experience points in the same direction; Linstad et al. (2024) traced how an inclusive governance model was used over a decade to align stakeholder interests with national eHealth ambitions, showing that the influence of participation on implementation is built, and can be lost, over time.

The link between participation and outcomes is also debated. A Norwegian study reported that municipal efforts to widen participation had very limited effect on trust in local politicians and no measurable effect on actual participation (Holum, 2023). In Argentina, informing voters about a participatory budgeting programme improved their view of government performance only marginally (Ardanaz et al., 2023), and a vignette experiment in South Korea produced a similarly modest effect of participatory policymaking on trust (Campbell, 2023). These findings caution against assuming that more participation automatically yields better results. What seems to matter is whether citizens can see that their input changed what government actually did.

In Africa, decentralisation reforms have multiplied the formal spaces for citizen engagement, but their performance has been uneven. In Uganda, Mukiga et al. (2024)

found that the absence of a formalised structure, such as a functioning health committee, weakened citizens' ability to shape local health services. In Mogadishu, Somalia, public participation was found to raise residents' trust in local government, partly because it made the city administration appear more responsive (Abdi et al., 2025). The continental picture, therefore, is one where participation holds promise but depends heavily on the institutions that surround it.

Kenya offers a particularly instructive case. The Constitution of Kenya (2010) lists public participation among the national values and principles of governance under Article 10(2)(a) and names the empowerment of citizens as an object of devolution under Article 174(c). The County Governments Act (2012) and the Public Finance Management Act (2012) require counties to create structures through which residents can take part in planning, budgeting and oversight. More recently, the national government adopted the Kenya Policy on Public Participation as Sessional Paper No. 3 of 2023 to harmonise practice across both levels of government (Republic of Kenya, 2023), and Parliament has been considering the Public Participation Bill, 2025, which seeks to set uniform standards for how participation is conducted (Republic of Kenya, 2025). Kenya therefore does not lack a legal basis for participation. What remains uncertain is whether that legal basis translates into real influence once policies move from paper to practice.

Empirical work in Kenyan counties suggests that the translation is incomplete. In Bungoma County, public participation was found to influence governance and, through it, sustainable development (Hao et al., 2022). In Kericho County, residents took part in budget preparation, public forums, scrutiny of records and the election of project leaders, but their overall participation across these modes was low (Ngeno et al., 2023). Studies in Laikipia County and across the 47 counties show that the choice of communication channel strongly shapes who attends and who is left out (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). At the national level, citizens' awareness of the Finance Act, 2023 was high, yet very few took part actively in its consideration, and most respondents judged the channels used, such as newspaper notices and public hearings, as ineffective in reaching ordinary people (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025).

Machakos County, which borders Nairobi to the east, provides a fitting setting in which to examine these issues. According to the 2019 census, the county had a population of 1,421,932 spread across urban centres such as Machakos Town and Athi River, fast-growing peri-urban areas along the Nairobi corridor, and largely rural, semi-arid zones such as Mwala, Masinga and Yatta (Kenya National Bureau of Statistics [KNBS], 2019). Since 2013 the county has used ward-level budget forums, sub-county development forums, sector working groups and public barazas to engage residents, and

it has more recently added online and SMS feedback platforms. Its current development blueprint commits the county to participatory planning and delivery across health, water, agriculture and infrastructure (County Government of Machakos [CGM], 2023). Yet research in Matungulu Sub-County showed that, although participation in the planning of water projects had a significant effect on their outcomes, the level of participation remained low relative to what the law envisages (Mutua et al., 2024). This contrast between an elaborate participatory architecture and modest levels of meaningful involvement forms the background to the present study.

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Ideally, public participation in a devolved system should ensure that county policies are shaped by the people they serve, carried out with their cooperation and monitored by them to completion. When this happens, projects are more likely to be finished on time, to meet their targets and to be protected by communities that regard them as their own (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). The Constitution of Kenya (2010) and the County Governments Act (2012) were written with this ideal in mind, and the Kenya Policy on Public Participation further commits both levels of government to meaningful, rather than symbolic, engagement (Republic of Kenya, 2023).

In practice, however, county policies in Kenya frequently fall short. Programmes are delayed, some facilities are completed but remain under-used, and residents often feel that forums are held to satisfy the law rather than to hear them (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Ngeno et al., 2023). In Machakos County, the development plan commits the county to participatory delivery of its programmes (CGM, 2023), yet a study in Matungulu found participation in water projects to be well below the level required by law, with consequences for the performance of those projects (Mutua et al., 2024). If this situation persists, the county risks investing public funds in policies that do not reflect residents' priorities, that face local resistance or neglect, and that erode public trust in devolution itself.

Although several studies have examined public participation in Kenya, most have concentrated on the planning and budgeting stages or on single sectors such as water, health facilities or construction (Katumo & Odenyo, 2024; Malusha & Njoroge, 2023; Mutua et al., 2024). Others have focused on the national legislative process rather than on county implementation (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025), or on communication channels rather than on outcomes (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). There is, as a result, little empirical evidence on how, and how far, public participation influences the implementation of policies across sectors in Machakos County. Without such evidence, neither the county government nor its residents can tell whether participatory structures

are working as intended or simply fulfilling a legal formality. This study seeks to fill that gap by examining the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government.

1.3 Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to examine the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government, Kenya, with a view to generating evidence that can strengthen participatory practice at the implementation stage of the county policy cycle.

1.4 Research Objectives

1.4.1 General Objective

The general objective of the study is to examine the influence of public participation on policy implementation in the Machakos County Government, Kenya.

1.4.2 Specific Objectives

The study will be guided by the following specific objectives:

- i. To establish the extent to which residents of Machakos County participate in the implementation of county government policies.
- ii. To assess the mechanisms used by the Machakos County Government to facilitate public participation in policy implementation.
- iii. To determine the challenges that hinder effective public participation in the implementation of county policies in Machakos County.
- iv. To examine the relationship between the level of public participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation in Machakos County.

1.5 Research Questions

The study will seek to answer the following questions:

- i. To what extent do residents of Machakos County participate in the implementation of county government policies?
- ii. What mechanisms does the Machakos County Government use to facilitate public participation in policy implementation?
- iii. What challenges hinder effective public participation in the implementation of county policies in Machakos County?
- iv. What is the relationship between the level of public participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation in Machakos County?

1.6 Research Hypothesis

In line with the fourth objective, the study will test the following null hypothesis at the 0.05 level of significance:

H₀₁: Public participation has no statistically significant influence on the effectiveness of policy implementation in the Machakos County Government.

1.7 Justification of the Study

The study is justified on three grounds. First, the Kenya Policy on Public Participation and the Public Participation Bill, 2025 signal a national effort to standardise participation (Republic of Kenya, 2023, 2025). Evidence from a county that has operated participatory structures for over a decade can inform how those standards are applied at the implementation stage. Second, Machakos County allocates a large share of its development budget to health, water, agriculture and roads (CGM, 2023), sectors in which community cooperation is essential for projects to succeed. Understanding how participation affects delivery in these sectors has direct value for public spending. Third, the study responds to calls in the literature to move beyond counting forums and toward understanding whether participation actually changes what government does (Jäntti et al., 2023; Kurkela et al., 2024).

1.8 Significance of the Study

The findings of this study are expected to benefit several groups. The Machakos County Government, particularly the departments responsible for public participation, finance and economic planning, will obtain evidence on which participation mechanisms residents find useful and which they regard as symbolic. This can guide the redesign of forums, feedback systems and project management committees.

The Council of Governors and other county governments operate under the same constitutional framework and face similar pressures. They may draw lessons from the study on how to connect citizen input with the delivery of programmes. National policy makers, including the drafters of public participation legislation, may use the findings to set standards that go beyond holding hearings and address feedback and follow-up.

Residents and civil society organisations in Machakos County will gain a clearer picture of how their involvement, or lack of it, shapes the services they receive, which may encourage more informed and sustained engagement. Finally, scholars of public administration and devolution will benefit from empirical evidence on participation at the implementation stage, an area that has received less attention than planning and budgeting in Kenyan research.

1.9 Limitations of the Study

Some residents may be reluctant to share honest opinions about county officials or programmes for fear of victimisation. To reduce this risk, the researcher will guarantee anonymity, avoid collecting names on questionnaires, and explain the academic purpose of the study before data collection. The study will also rely partly on self-reported perceptions of implementation effectiveness, which may not match official performance records. Where possible, the researcher will compare responses with county progress and budget implementation reports. In addition, the semi-arid and dispersed nature of rural wards such as those in Mwala may make it costly to reach respondents. This will be addressed by engaging trained research assistants who are familiar with the area and by scheduling visits around market days and local meetings.

1.10 Delimitations of the Study

The study will be confined to the Machakos County Government and will focus on public participation in the implementation, rather than the formulation, of county policies. Geographically, it will cover three of the county's sub-counties, namely Machakos Town, Matungulu and Mwala, which represent urban, peri-urban and rural settings respectively. The respondents will be adult residents aged 18 years and above together with selected county officials. The study will consider policies, programmes and projects implemented within the five years preceding data collection, a period that falls under the current development plan (CGM, 2023).

1.11 Assumptions of the Study

The study assumes that respondents will provide honest and accurate answers; that residents in the selected sub-counties have had some exposure to county policy implementation activities within the reference period; that county officials will grant access to relevant documents and be available for interviews; and that the three sampled sub-counties reasonably reflect the diversity of participation experiences within Machakos County.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

This chapter reviews literature related to public participation and policy implementation. It begins with the theories that anchor the study, followed by an empirical review organised around the four specific objectives. It then presents the conceptual framework, a critique of the reviewed literature, and a summary of the research gaps the study intends to fill.

2.2 Theoretical Review

The study is guided by two complementary theories. Arnstein's Ladder of Citizen Participation explains the depth of citizen influence, while the Theory of Co-production explains why citizen involvement matters for the delivery of public services and policies.

2.2.1 Ladder of Citizen Participation

The Ladder of Citizen Participation was advanced by Arnstein (1969), who argued that participation is fundamentally about the redistribution of power. She arranged forms of participation along eight rungs grouped into three levels. The lowest level, comprising manipulation and therapy, represents non-participation. The middle level, made up of informing, consultation and placation, represents degrees of tokenism in which citizens may be heard but lack the power to ensure their views are acted upon. The upper level, covering partnership, delegated power and citizen control, represents genuine citizen power. The central argument of the theory is that participation without a transfer of influence is an empty ritual that allows authorities to claim that everyone was consulted while only some benefit.

The ladder remains widely used because it offers a clear way of judging not only whether participation occurred but how deep it went (Abas et al., 2023). It has, however, been criticised for treating participation as a single hierarchy in which more control is always better, and for overlooking the fact that citizens may prefer different forms of involvement for different issues (De Weger et al., 2022). It also says little about the institutional arrangements needed to move up the ladder. Despite these limitations, the theory is relevant to this study because Kenya's legal framework is written in the language of the upper rungs, while empirical studies suggest that practice often settles on the middle rungs of informing and consultation (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Ngeno et al., 2023). The theory therefore informs the first and second objectives, by providing a

yardstick for gauging the extent and depth of participation and for classifying the mechanisms the county uses.

2.2.2 Theory of Co-production

The Theory of Co-production is associated with Ostrom (1996), who observed that the quality of many public services depends on the contributions of both public officials and the citizens who use them. In her view, citizens are not simply consumers of services but active producers whose knowledge, effort and cooperation are needed for services to work. Co-production is most likely to succeed when the inputs of government and citizens complement each other, and when legal and institutional arrangements make such collaboration possible. Later scholarship has extended the idea to four related activities: co-commissioning, co-design, co-delivery and co-assessment of public services (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021).

The theory has been criticised for placing extra burdens on citizens, especially the poor, who may lack the time and resources to contribute, and for blurring lines of accountability when outcomes are shared (Loeffler & Bovaird, 2021). Nonetheless, it is relevant to this study because it moves the discussion beyond decision-making into the delivery of policies. It suggests that policies are more likely to be implemented effectively when residents take part in monitoring projects, contributing local knowledge and protecting completed facilities. The theory therefore underpins the third and fourth objectives, by explaining why barriers to participation weaken implementation and why higher levels of participation should be associated with better implementation outcomes.

2.3 Empirical Review

This section reviews studies related to each of the four specific objectives.

2.3.1 Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation

Several studies indicate that citizen participation in county affairs in Kenya is broad in form but shallow in substance. Ngeno et al. (2023) used a concurrent mixed-methods design in Kericho County and found that residents took part in budget preparation, attended public forums, scrutinised records, elected project leaders and attended seminars, yet participation across all of these modes was low. The study was limited to development projects and did not link participation to implementation outcomes, which the present study will do.

In Machakos County, Mutua et al. (2024) collected data from 220 household heads, a water project manager and eight water user committee representatives in Matungulu Sub-County. They found that participation in the planning phase had a significant

influence on the outcomes of water projects, but that actual levels of involvement were low compared with what the legal framework envisages. Because their study focused on the planning phase of water projects, it leaves open the question of how residents participate once policies across different sectors are being implemented.

A similar pattern emerges at the national level. Maiyo and Kinuthia (2025), studying 86 respondents drawn from citizens, civil society and policy makers, reported that although many people were aware of the Finance Act, 2023, only a small proportion took part actively in its consideration. Abas et al. (2023), in a systematic review of a decade of research on participation in local authority planning, similarly concluded that participation is often limited to the early stages of decision-making and seldom extends into delivery. These studies collectively suggest that the extent of participation in implementation is likely to be modest, a proposition this study will test in Machakos County.

2.3.2 Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation

The channels through which counties invite citizen input strongly influence who participates. In Laikipia County, Wambugu et al. (2024) found that the mode of communication significantly affected the level of participation, with face-to-face contact and SMS messages being the most effective in mobilising residents to attend public participation meetings. Wasike et al. (2024), in a qualitative assessment of communication frameworks across Kenya's 47 counties, observed that the approaches used to publicise participation opportunities varied widely in their reach and effectiveness. Maiyo and Kinuthia (2025) reported that newspaper adverts, written memoranda and public hearings dominated participation in the Finance Act, 2023, yet the overwhelming majority of respondents considered them ineffective in reaching a broad section of the population.

Digital channels have been proposed as a way of widening access. A systematic review of e-participation by Benlahcene et al. (2024) found that online platforms can make participation more convenient, but that citizens face obstacles such as limited digital skills, poor connectivity and low trust in how their contributions are handled. Internationally, De Weger et al. (2022) showed that citizens were more willing to engage when municipalities used accessible language and explained how their input would be used, while Linstad et al. (2024) demonstrated how a formal stakeholder board could serve as a standing mechanism for aligning interests during implementation. These studies focus mainly on the design and reach of mechanisms; few examine whether particular mechanisms are associated with better implementation outcomes at the county level, which is an aim of this study.

2.3.3 Challenges Hindering Effective Public Participation

The literature identifies a range of barriers. Hao et al. (2022), using structural equation modelling on data from Bungoma County, found that the integration of participation into governance faced several challenges that weakened its contribution to sustainable development. Kurkela et al. (2024), drawing on interviews with 14 key actors in the city of Helsinki, identified organisational structures, organisational culture and adequate resources as the three pillars of influential participation, implying that weaknesses in any of these become barriers. Jäntti et al. (2023) added that participation falters when citizen input is collected at one level of the organisation but not carried through to the units responsible for execution.

In Uganda, Mukiga et al. (2024) interviewed 66 participants, including health workers, residents, local councillors and administrators, and found that the lack of a formalised citizen participation structure, specifically the absence of an active health committee, prevented residents from influencing how local health services were delivered. Benlahcene et al. (2024) pointed to digital divides as a further barrier, while Maiyo and Kinuthia (2025) highlighted short notice periods and inaccessible venues. Although these studies are informative, they were conducted in different settings and sectors. The specific combination of barriers facing residents of Machakos County, where urban, peri-urban and rural conditions coexist, has not been systematically documented.

2.3.4 Public Participation and Effectiveness of Policy Implementation

A growing body of evidence links participation to implementation outcomes. Katumo and Odenyo (2024) examined public participation in the implementation of county government projects in Makueni County, a neighbouring county widely cited for its participatory budgeting model, and reported that citizen involvement was associated with the implementation of county projects. Malusha and Njoroge (2023) studied the effects of informing, consultation, collaboration and empowerment on the implementation of the County Integrated Development Plan in Voi Sub-County, Taita Taveta, drawing on participatory democracy theory. Mutua et al. (2024) likewise showed that participation in the planning of water projects in Matungulu significantly influenced their outcomes.

The international evidence adds an important qualification. Abdi et al. (2025), surveying 446 residents of Mogadishu, found that participation increased trust in local government partly because it made the administration appear more responsive. On the other hand, Holum (2023) found that government efforts to widen participation in Norwegian municipalities had very limited effect on trust, and Ardanaz et al. (2023) and Campbell (2023) reported only marginal gains in trust from information about, or

experience of, participatory processes. Taken together, these studies suggest that participation is most likely to improve implementation when citizens can see that their input led to change. Most of the Kenyan studies, however, have focused on single sectors or on the planning stage. This study will examine the relationship across sectors and at the implementation stage in Machakos County.

2.4 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework in Figure 2.1 shows the hypothesised relationship between public participation, the independent variable, and the effectiveness of policy implementation, the dependent variable. Public participation is operationalised through three dimensions drawn from the specific objectives: the level of participation, the mechanisms used to facilitate it, and the barriers that constrain it. The effectiveness of policy implementation is measured by timely delivery, attainment of targets, beneficiary satisfaction and community ownership. Institutional capacity, political goodwill and availability of budgetary resources are treated as intervening variables that may affect the strength of the relationship.

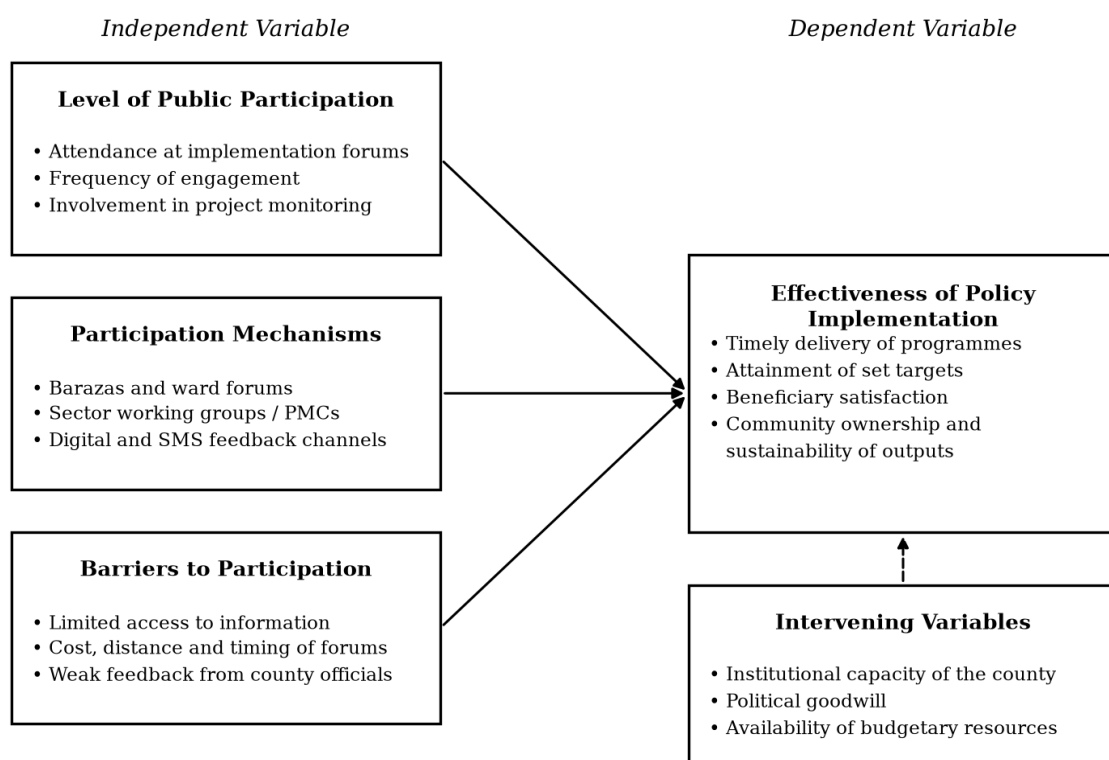


Figure 2.1: Conceptual Framework

Source: Researcher (2026)

2.5 Critique of Existing Literature

The reviewed literature has three notable weaknesses. First, many Kenyan studies examine participation at the planning or budgeting stage and assume that its benefits carry over into implementation (Malusha & Njoroge, 2023; Mutua et al., 2024). This assumption is seldom tested. Second, a number of studies rely on small samples or single-sector cases, such as water projects or health facilities, which limits the extent to which their findings apply across a county's policy portfolio (Katumo & Odenyo, 2024; Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025). Third, studies on mechanisms tend to measure reach and attendance rather than influence, so they reveal who came to a forum but not whether the forum changed anything (Wambugu et al., 2024; Wasike et al., 2024). The international literature is richer on organisational and trust-related questions (Holum, 2023; Kurkela et al., 2024), but it comes from contexts with stronger institutions and higher resource levels than Kenyan counties. This study addresses these weaknesses by combining a cross-sectoral survey with key informant interviews, and by focusing explicitly on the implementation stage.

2.6 Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

The literature shows broad agreement that public participation matters for governance and service delivery, but it also reveals that participation in Kenyan counties is often low, channelled through mechanisms of limited reach, and hindered by institutional, informational and economic barriers. Table 2.1 summarises the key studies reviewed and the gaps the present study intends to address.

Table 2.1: Summary of Research Gaps

Author(s)	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Knowledge Gap
Mutua et al. (2024)	Planning-phase participation and water project outcomes, Matungulu	Participation significantly influenced outcomes, but levels were low	Focused on planning and one sector; this study covers implementation across sectors
Ngeno et al. (2023)	Modes of participation, Kericho County	Participation across all modes was low	Did not link participation to outcomes; this study tests the relationship
Maiyo & Kinuthia (2025)	Participation in the Finance Act, 2023	Channels used were judged ineffective by most respondents	National legislative focus; this study examines county implementation
Katumo & Odenyo (2024)	Participation and county project implementation, Makueni	Citizen involvement associated with project implementation	Different county context; this study focuses on Machakos

Author(s)	Focus of Study	Key Findings	Knowledge Gap
Wambugu et al. (2024)	Communication modes and participation, Laikipia	Face-to-face and SMS most effective for mobilisation	Measured attendance, not influence on implementation
Kurkela et al. (2024)	Organisational prerequisites for participation, Helsinki	Structures, culture and resources determine influence	High-capacity European setting; this study examines a Kenyan county

Source: Researcher (2026)

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter describes the methodology that will be used to conduct the study. It covers the research design, location of the study, target population, sampling techniques and sample size, research instruments, pilot testing, validity and reliability, data collection procedures, data analysis and presentation, and ethical considerations.

3.2 Research Design

The study will adopt a descriptive cross-sectional survey design complemented by qualitative key informant interviews. A descriptive design is suitable where the researcher seeks to describe the characteristics of a population and the relationships among variables as they exist, without manipulating them (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). The cross-sectional element means that data will be gathered at one point in time, which is practical given the time and resources available for the study. Combining a survey with interviews follows a convergent mixed-methods logic in which quantitative data measure the extent and correlates of participation, while qualitative data explain the patterns observed (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). A similar approach was used successfully in comparable Kenyan studies (Maiyo & Kinuthia, 2025; Mutua et al., 2024).

3.3 Location of the Study

The study will be conducted in Machakos County, one of the 47 counties established under the Constitution of Kenya (2010). The county covers an area of about 6,000 square kilometres and borders Nairobi, Kiambu, Murang'a, Embu, Kitui, Makueni and Kajiado counties. It had a population of 1,421,932 at the 2019 census (KNBS, 2019). The county was chosen for three reasons. First, it combines urban, peri-urban and rural settings within a single administrative unit, allowing the study to capture varied participation experiences. Second, it has operated a range of participation structures since 2013, including ward forums, sector working groups and digital platforms (CGM, 2023). Third, earlier research in the county has documented a gap between legal requirements and actual participation (Mutua et al., 2024), making it a suitable site for examining the implementation stage. The study will focus on Machakos Town Sub-County (urban), Matungulu Sub-County (peri-urban) and Mwala Sub-County (rural).

3.4 Target Population

The target population will consist of two groups. The first comprises residents of the three selected sub-counties, totalling 514,059 people according to the 2019 census (KNBS, 2019). The second comprises county officials directly involved in public participation and policy implementation, namely the three sub-county administrators, the 18 ward administrators in the selected sub-counties, and officers from the departments responsible for public participation and civic education, finance and economic planning, health, and water. Table 3.1 presents the distribution of the resident population.

Table 3.1: Target Population of Residents

Sub-County	Setting	Population (2019)	Percentage
Machakos Town	Urban	170,606	33.2
Matungulu	Peri-urban	161,557	31.4
Mwala	Rural	181,896	35.4
Total		514,059	100.0

Source: KNBS (2019)

3.5 Sampling Techniques and Sample Size

3.5.1 Sampling Techniques

The study will use multi-stage sampling. In the first stage, the three sub-counties will be selected purposively to represent urban, peri-urban and rural settings, since access to participation opportunities is likely to vary across these settings (Wambugu et al., 2024). In the second stage, the sample of residents will be allocated to each sub-county in proportion to its population. In the third stage, respondents will be selected through simple random sampling of households within each ward, using ward registers and village maps with the support of village administrators, and one adult will be interviewed per household. Key informants will be selected through purposive sampling because they hold specific knowledge about how participation is organised and how county policies are implemented (Saunders et al., 2023).

3.5.2 Sample Size

The sample size for residents will be determined using Yamane's (1967) formula for a finite population at a 95% confidence level and a margin of error of 5%:

$$n = N / (1 + N e^2)$$

where n is the sample size, N is the target population (514,059) and e is the margin of error (0.05). Substituting the values gives $n = 514,059 / (1 + 514,059 \times 0.0025) = 399.7$,

which is rounded to 400 respondents. Table 3.2 shows the proportionate distribution of the sample, and Table 3.3 shows the key informants.

Table 3.2: Sample Size Distribution of Residents

Sub-County	Population	Proportion	Sample Size
Machakos Town	170,606	0.332	133
Matungulu	161,557	0.314	126
Mwala	181,896	0.354	141
Total	514,059	1.000	400

Source: Researcher (2026)

Table 3.3: Sample of Key Informants

Category	Number	Sampling Technique
Sub-county administrators	3	Census
Ward administrators	18	Census
Departmental officers (public participation, finance and economic planning, health, water)	8	Purposive (2 per department)
Total	29	

Source: Researcher (2026)

The total sample for the study will therefore be 429 respondents, comprising 400 residents and 29 key informants.

3.6 Research Instruments

Two instruments will be used. A structured questionnaire will be administered to residents. It will have five sections: demographic information; extent of participation; participation mechanisms; challenges to participation; and effectiveness of policy implementation. Most items will be presented on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree), with a few open-ended items to capture views not anticipated by the researcher. The questionnaire will be translated into Kiswahili and Kikamba and back-translated to English to ensure that meaning is preserved. A semi-structured interview guide will be used with key informants to explore how participation is organised, how citizen input is used during implementation, and what constraints the county faces. Relevant county documents, such as annual development plans, budget implementation reports and public participation reports, will also be reviewed to support triangulation.

Table 3.4: Operationalisation of Study Variables

Variable	Type	Indicators	Measurement
Level of public participation	Independent	Attendance at forums; frequency of engagement; involvement in monitoring	Five-point Likert scale
Participation mechanisms	Independent	Barazas; ward forums; sector working groups; PMCs; digital and SMS channels	Five-point Likert scale
Barriers to participation	Independent	Access to information; cost and distance; timing; feedback from officials	Five-point Likert scale
Effectiveness of policy implementation	Dependent	Timeliness; target attainment; beneficiary satisfaction; ownership and sustainability	Five-point Likert scale

Source: Researcher (2026)

3.7 Pilot Testing

The instruments will be pre-tested in Kathiani Sub-County, which shares many characteristics with the study area but will not form part of the main sample. The pilot will involve 40 residents, representing 10% of the main sample, and three key informants. The pilot will help identify unclear or ambiguous items, estimate the time needed to complete the questionnaire, and test the reliability of the scales. Items found to be problematic will be revised before the main data collection.

3.7.1 Validity of Research Instruments

Validity refers to the degree to which an instrument measures what it is intended to measure (Saunders et al., 2023). Content validity will be established by aligning each item with the study objectives and the conceptual framework, and by subjecting the instruments to review by the university supervisors and two experts in public administration. The experts will rate the relevance of each item, and a Content Validity Index (CVI) will be computed; a CVI of 0.80 or higher will be considered acceptable. Face validity will be enhanced through the pilot study.

3.7.2 Reliability of Research Instruments

Reliability is the consistency with which an instrument produces similar results under similar conditions (Creswell & Creswell, 2023). The internal consistency of the Likert-scale items will be tested using Cronbach's alpha on the pilot data. A coefficient of 0.70 or above for each construct will be considered acceptable; items that reduce the coefficient below this threshold will be reviewed or removed. For the qualitative component, credibility and dependability will be enhanced through triangulation with

documents, careful note-taking, audio recording with consent, and an audit trail of analytical decisions (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

3.8 Data Collection Procedures

After approval of the proposal, the researcher will obtain an introduction letter from Mount Kenya University, ethical clearance from the university's ethics review committee, and a research permit from the National Commission for Science, Technology and Innovation (NACOSTI). Authority will also be sought from the Machakos County Government and the County Commissioner. Six research assistants, recruited from the study area and fluent in Kikamba and Kiswahili, will be trained for two days on the instruments, sampling procedures and research ethics. Questionnaires will be administered face to face, with assistants reading items to respondents who prefer this. The researcher will personally conduct all key informant interviews at times convenient to the officials. Completed questionnaires will be checked daily for completeness and consistency.

3.9 Data Analysis and Presentation

Quantitative data will be cleaned, coded and entered into the Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS) version 29. Descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, means and standard deviations, will be used to address the first three objectives. For the fourth objective, Pearson's product-moment correlation will be used to establish the strength and direction of the relationship between public participation and the effectiveness of policy implementation. Simple linear regression will then be used to test the null hypothesis, based on the following model:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X + \varepsilon$$

where Y is the effectiveness of policy implementation, β_0 is the constant, β_1 is the coefficient of public participation, X is the composite public participation index, and ε is the error term. To estimate the relative contribution of each dimension, a supplementary multiple regression model will be fitted:

$$Y = \beta_0 + \beta_1 X_1 + \beta_2 X_2 + \beta_3 X_3 + \varepsilon$$

where X_1 is the level of participation, X_2 is the adequacy of participation mechanisms and X_3 is the severity of barriers to participation. Before the regression is run, the assumptions of normality, linearity, homoscedasticity and absence of multicollinearity will be tested. The null hypothesis will be rejected if the p-value is less than 0.05. Qualitative data from interviews and open-ended items will be transcribed, coded and analysed thematically following the six-phase approach described by Braun and Clarke

(2022). Findings will be presented in tables, figures and narrative form, with direct quotations used to illustrate key themes.

3.10 Ethical Considerations

The study will observe the ethical standards required of research involving human participants. Ethical approval will be obtained from the Mount Kenya University ethics review committee, and a research permit will be obtained from NACOSTI. Participation will be voluntary, and informed consent will be sought from every respondent after the purpose, procedures, risks and benefits of the study have been explained. Respondents will be free to decline any question or to withdraw at any stage without penalty. No names or identifying details will be recorded on questionnaires, and interview transcripts will be anonymised using codes. Data will be stored in password-protected files accessible only to the researcher and supervisors, and will be used solely for academic purposes. All sources consulted will be properly acknowledged to avoid plagiarism, and the findings will be shared with the Machakos County Government and participating communities in an accessible summary.

REFERENCES

- Abas, A., Arifin, K., Ali, M. A. M., & Khairil, M. (2023). A systematic literature review on public participation in decision-making for local authority planning: A decade of progress and challenges. *Environmental Development*, 46, Article 100853. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.envdev.2023.100853>
- Abdi, A.-N. M., Nageye, A. I., & Sabriye, H. O. (2025). Examining the effects of public participation on residents' trust in local government: The mediating effect of perceived responsiveness. *PLOS ONE*, 20(5), Article e0323047. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0323047>
- Ardanaz, M., Otálvaro-Ramírez, S., & Scartascini, C. (2023). Does information about citizen participation initiatives increase political trust? *World Development*, 162, Article 106132. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.worlddev.2022.106132>
- Arnstein, S. R. (1969). A ladder of citizen participation. *Journal of the American Institute of Planners*, 35(4), 216–224. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01944366908977225>
- Benlahcene, A., Awang, H., Mansor, N. S., Ghazali, O., Nadzir, M. M., Haruna, I. U., Yamin, F. M., & Malami, S. T. S. (2024). Citizens' e-participation through e-government services: A systematic literature review. *Cogent Social Sciences*, 10(1), Article 2415526. <https://doi.org/10.1080/23311886.2024.2415526>
- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2022). *Thematic analysis: A practical guide*. SAGE Publications.
- Campbell, J. W. (2023). Public participation and trust in government: Results from a vignette experiment. *Journal of Policy Studies*, 38(2), 23–31. https://www.ejps.org/archive/view_article?pid=jps-38-2-23
- Constitution of Kenya. (2010). Government Printer. <http://kenyalaw.org/kl/index.php?id=398>
- County Government of Machakos. (2023). *County integrated development plan 2023–2027*. <https://machakos.go.ke/download/county-integrated-development-plan-2023-2027/>
- County Governments Act, No. 17 of 2012 (Kenya). http://kenyalaw.org/kl/fileadmin/pdfdownloads/Acts/CountyGovernmentsAct_No17of2012.pdf
- Creswell, J. W., & Creswell, J. D. (2023). *Research design: Qualitative, quantitative, and mixed methods approaches* (6th ed.). SAGE Publications.

- De Weger, E., Drewes, H. W., Van Vooren, N. J. E., Luijkx, K. G., & Baan, C. A. (2022). Engaging citizens in local health policymaking. A realist explorative case-study. *PLOS ONE*, 17(3), Article e0265404. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0265404>
- Hao, C., Nyaranga, M. S., & Hongo, D. O. (2022). Enhancing public participation in governance for sustainable development: Evidence from Bungoma County, Kenya. *SAGE Open*, 12(1). <https://doi.org/10.1177/21582440221088855>
- Holum, M. (2023). Citizen participation: Linking government efforts, actual participation, and trust in local politicians. *International Journal of Public Administration*, 46(13), 915–925. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01900692.2022.2048667>
- Jäntti, A., Paananen, H., Kork, A.-A., & Kurkela, K. (2023). Towards interactive governance: Embedding citizen participation in local government. *Administration & Society*, 55(8), 1529–1554. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00953997231177220>
- Katumo, A., & Odenyo, M. (2024). Influence of public participation on implementation of county government projects: Case of Makueni County, Kenya. *International Journal of Current Aspects*, 8(2), 1–19. <https://doi.org/10.35942/9yk7p690>
- Kenya National Bureau of Statistics. (2019). *2019 Kenya population and housing census: Volume I. Population by county and sub-county*. KNBS.
- Kurkela, K., Kork, A.-A., Jäntti, A., & Paananen, H. (2024). Citizen participation as an organisational challenge in local government. *International Journal of Public Sector Management*, 37(1), 124–140. <https://doi.org/10.1108/IJPSM-08-2022-0179>
- Linstad, L. H., Bjørnå, H., Moen, A., Kristiansen, T. T., & Hansen, A. H. (2024). Investigating the Norwegian eHealth governance model: Document study. *Journal of Medical Internet Research*, 26, Article e59717. <https://doi.org/10.2196/59717>
- Loeffler, E., & Bovaird, T. (Eds.). (2021). *The Palgrave handbook of co-production of public services and outcomes*. Palgrave Macmillan. <https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-53705-0>
- Maiyo, C., & Kinuthia, P. M. (2025). Public participation and the legislative process in Kenya: A case of Finance Act, 2023. *International Journal of Research and*

Innovation in Social Science, 9(9), 7639–7651.
<https://doi.org/10.47772/IJRISS.2025.909000624>

- Malusha, A. J., & Njoroge, J. (2023). Effects of public participation practices on implementation of county integrated development plan (CIDP) in Kenya: A case of Taita Taveta County, Kenya. *Reviewed Journal of Social Science & Humanities*, 4(1), 178–214.
- Mukiga, A. K., Boadu, E. S., & Edson, T. (2024). Perceived public participation and health delivery in local government districts in Uganda. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 21(7), Article 820.
<https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph21070820>
- Mutua, E. K., Ndeke, G. C. W., & Mboga, M. K. (2024). Influence of public participation in the planning phase on the outcome of water projects in Matungulu Sub-County, Machakos County. *Journal of Policy and Development Studies*, 3(1), 27–42. <https://doi.org/10.51317/jpds.v3i1.539>
- Ngeno, E. K., Matui, B. N., & Onduru, T. A. (2023). Effectiveness and usage of various modes of public participation in Kericho County, Kenya. *International Journal of Research and Innovation in Social Science*, 7(10).
<https://doi.org/10.47772/IJRISS.2023.701022>
- Ostrom, E. (1996). Crossing the great divide: Coproduction, synergy, and development. *World Development*, 24(6), 1073–1087.
[https://doi.org/10.1016/0305-750X\(96\)00023-X](https://doi.org/10.1016/0305-750X(96)00023-X)
- Public Finance Management Act, No. 18 of 2012 (Kenya).
http://kenyalaw.org/kl/fileadmin/pdfdownloads/Acts/PublicFinanceManagementAct_No18of2012.pdf
- Republic of Kenya. (2023). *Kenya policy on public participation* (Sessional Paper No. 3 of 2023). Government Printer.
- Republic of Kenya. (2025). *The Public Participation Bill, 2025*. National Assembly.
<https://new.kenyalaw.org/akn/ke/bill/na/2025-10-01/the-public-participation-bill-2025/eng@2025-10-01>
- Saunders, M. N. K., Lewis, P., & Thornhill, A. (2023). *Research methods for business students* (9th ed.). Pearson.
- Wambugu, J., Gichuhi, D., & Ndung'u, K. (2024). Influence of modes of communication on public participation in Laikipia County, Kenya. *International Journal of Research in Business and Social Science*, 13(6), 464–470. <https://doi.org/10.20525/ijrbs.v13i6.3612>

Wasike, E. M., Lumala, M., & Malel, J. (2024). Effectiveness of county communication approaches in facilitating public participation in Kenya's devolved governments. *American Journal of Communication*, 6(1), 12–23. <https://doi.org/10.47672/ajc.1884>

Yamane, T. (1967). *Statistics: An introductory analysis* (2nd ed.). Harper & Row.

APPENDICES

Appendix I: Letter of Introduction

Dear Respondent,

RE: REQUEST TO PARTICIPATE IN A RESEARCH STUDY

I am a postgraduate student at Mount Kenya University, School of Business and Economics, pursuing a Master's degree in Public Administration. I am conducting a study entitled "Influence of Public Participation on Policy Implementation in Machakos County Government, Kenya" in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the award of the degree.

You have been selected to take part in this study. Kindly spare about 20 minutes to respond to the attached questionnaire. The information you provide will be treated with strict confidentiality and will be used only for academic purposes. Your name will not appear anywhere in the report.

Thank you for your time and cooperation.

Yours faithfully,

[Student Name]

Reg. No. [Registration Number]

Appendix II: Informed Consent Form

I have been informed of the purpose of this study, the procedures involved, and my right to decline any question or to withdraw at any time without any consequence. I understand that my responses will be kept confidential and used solely for academic purposes. I therefore voluntarily agree to take part in this study.

Signature/Thumbprint of respondent: _____ Date: _____

Signature of researcher: _____ Date: _____

Appendix III: Questionnaire for Residents

Instructions: Please tick (✓) the appropriate box or write your answer in the space provided. Do not write your name on this questionnaire.

Section A: Demographic Information

1. Gender: Male ☐ Female ☐
2. Age bracket (years): 18–25 ☐ 26–35 ☐ 36–45 ☐ 46–55 ☐ Above 55 ☐
3. Highest level of education: None ☐ Primary ☐ Secondary ☐ College ☐ University ☐
4. Sub-County of residence: Machakos Town ☐ Matungulu ☐ Mwala ☐
5. Length of residence in the ward: Below 2 years ☐ 2–5 years ☐ 6–10 years ☐ Above 10 years ☐
6. Main occupation: Farming ☐ Business ☐ Formal employment ☐ Casual work ☐ Other ☐

Section B: Extent of Public Participation in Policy Implementation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
7	I have attended at least one county forum on the implementation of a county project or programme in the last two years.					
8	I am regularly informed about county projects being implemented in my ward.					
9	I have been involved in monitoring the progress of a county project in my area.					
10	Residents in my ward are consulted when changes are made to projects during implementation.					
11	My views have influenced how a county project was carried out in my area.					
12	Residents are represented in project management committees in my ward.					

Section C: Mechanisms for Facilitating Public Participation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
13	Public barazas are an effective way for residents to give views on county projects.					
14	Ward development forums give residents a real opportunity to influence implementation.					
15	Sector working groups (e.g. health, water, agriculture) involve ordinary residents.					
16	Project management committees effectively represent community interests.					
17	The county's online and SMS platforms make it easy for me to give feedback.					
18	Notices of public participation forums are communicated in good time and in a language I understand.					

Section D: Challenges Hindering Public Participation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
19	I lack adequate information about county policies and projects.					
20	Forums are held at times that are inconvenient for me.					
21	The cost of travelling to forum venues discourages me from attending.					
22	County officials rarely give feedback on how residents' views were used.					
23	Participation forums are dominated by political or elite interests.					
24	Women, youth and persons with disabilities face extra difficulties in participating.					

Section E: Effectiveness of Policy Implementation

Key: 1 = Strongly Disagree; 2 = Disagree; 3 = Neutral; 4 = Agree; 5 = Strongly Agree

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
25	County projects in my ward are completed within the planned time.					

No.	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
26	County projects in my ward achieve the targets they were designed for.					
27	I am satisfied with the services delivered through county projects in my ward.					
28	Residents in my ward take care of and protect completed county projects.					
29	County projects in my ward address the priorities raised by residents.					
30	Completed county projects in my ward continue to function well over time.					

Section F: General Comments

31. In your opinion, what should the Machakos County Government do to improve public participation in the implementation of its policies and projects?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

Thank you for your participation.

Appendix IV: Interview Guide for Key Informants

Introduction: The researcher will give a brief self-introduction, explain the purpose of the study, assure the respondent of confidentiality, and seek consent to take notes and record the interview.

1. Please describe your role in public participation and the implementation of county policies.
2. How does the county involve residents once a policy, programme or project has been approved for implementation?
3. Which participation mechanisms have been most effective in your area, and why?
4. How is the feedback received from residents used during implementation? Could you give an example?
5. What challenges does the county face in facilitating public participation during implementation?
6. What challenges do residents face in taking part in implementation processes?
7. In your experience, how has public participation affected the timeliness, quality and sustainability of county projects?
8. How do institutional capacity, political goodwill and budgetary resources affect participation in implementation?
9. What measures would you recommend to strengthen public participation in policy implementation in Machakos County?

Appendix V: Work Plan

Activity	Timeline
Development and approval of the research proposal	Oct – Dec 2026
Proposal defence and corrections	Jan 2027
Ethical clearance and NACOSTI research permit	Feb 2027
Pilot testing and refinement of instruments	Feb 2027
Field data collection	Mar – Apr 2027
Data analysis and interpretation	May 2027
Thesis writing and submission to supervisors	Jun – Jul 2027
Thesis defence, corrections and final submission	Aug 2027

Appendix VI: Research Budget

Budget Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Literature and reference materials	10,000
Training and remuneration of 6 research assistants	48,000
Transport and logistics within Machakos County	30,000
Printing, photocopying and questionnaire reproduction	15,000
Translation of instruments (Kiswahili and Kikamba)	6,000
Communication and airtime	5,000
Data analysis software and services	15,000
Ethical review and NACOSTI permit fees	6,000
Thesis printing, binding and dissemination	10,000
Subtotal	145,000
Contingency (10%)	14,500
Total	159,500